Backlog Refinement

Get the next few items ordered, understood, split, sized and ready, in one focused session.

Run Events · Backlog Refinement · Order → Understand → Split → Example → Size → Ready

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM: Basket team

DATE: 6 May

1 Session Goal

REFINE JUST ENOUGH, JUST IN TIME

Items to refine: the top 5 in the backlog

Ready for (iteration or date): iteration 6 (from 12 May)

Who's here: Priya, Sam, Jo, Alex, Mei

2 Refinement Flow

FOR EACH ITEM, IN ORDER · STOP WHEN IT'S READY

1 Order

Is this still the most valuable next item?
→ Prioritisation Board

Reorder from history moves up; Save favourites moves down

Our note: Customer panel cares less about favourites

2 Understand

Who is it for, and why?
What does done look like?
→ Backlog Item Anatomy

For weekly shoppers. Done when the basket refills and gaps are flagged

Our note: Substitutes: only for out-of-stock items

3 Split

Can we finish it in a few days? If not, slice it.
→ Story Splitting

Substitutes → (a) flag missing items (b) suggest swaps

Our note: Split by rule: in-stock first, then swaps

4 Examples

Rules, examples and open questions.
→ Example Mapping

Bread out of stock → shown as unavailable

Our note: Mapped reorder (4 rules) and substitutes (3)

5 Size

Roughly how big, compared with things we've done?
→ Estimation

Flag missing: S · Suggest swaps: L

Our note: All S or M except Suggest swaps (L)

6 Ready?

Check it against our Definition of Ready.
→ panel 4, below

Flag missing ✓ · Suggest swaps ✗ (needs Stock API)

Our note: 2 ready, 1 half ready, 2 need answers first

3 Items Refined

ITEM	SPLIT INTO	EXAMPLES AGREED	SIZE	READY?	OPEN QUESTIONS & OWNER
Reorder from history	–	yes	M	✓	–
Substitutes	flag missing; suggest swaps	yes	S, L	half	Stock API date? (Sam)
Save favourites	–	yes	S	✓	–
Share basket with family	–	partly	S	✗	privacy wording (Priya)
Usual-item reminders	email; in-app	no	M	✗	consent wording (Mei)

4 Definition of Ready

A GUIDE, NOT A GATE

- [x] Who it's for and why is clear
- [x] Small enough to finish in a few days
- [x] Examples or acceptance criteria agreed
- [ ] Dependencies known and handled
- [x] No open question that would stop work

Next refinement: Tuesday 13 May, 45 minutes

"Which items do we need ready for the next iteration?"

"What don't we know yet that would stop us starting?"

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